Health and pleasure

Hello everyone! This is episode nineteen of the Cottongue Podcast!

[00:00:10] Welcome to this new episode. How are you today? I'm very well! Summer is nearly over and unfortunately I haven't had much holiday. But I used the time to work and prepare well for the return to school and work. "La rentrée" is the period at the beginning of September when everyone returns from holiday and pupils return to school. Generally, it's very busy, with lots to do. But working hard in August let me get ahead. Do you understand "to get ahead"? It means preparing to be ahead in your work. For example, for a new project on 15 September, begin a little earlier to get ahead. That's what I did in August. I was a little jealous seeing friends post paradise-beach photos while I worked, but now I'm very happy with my decision!

[00:01:37] Did you get ahead during the holidays, or instead fall behind? Either way, I hope your return goes well: without stress and with a smile!

[00:01:55] This return is often a time for good resolutions. Making a good resolution means deciding to begin something important, such as exercise or a new language, or stop something bad, like cigarettes or sweets. I'll take this opportunity to remind you about "prendre une décision". Many people, especially our English-speaking friends, incorrectly say "faire une décision". In French, we use "prendre", to take, rather than "faire", to make, with decisions.

[00:02:48] Many resolutions concern health, meaning physical and mental well-being. Well-being simply means feeling good. Healthy people feel good, aren't ill and can exert themselves physically. Virgil, the Roman poet, wrote, "The greatest wealth is health." In September, we want to keep the energy recovered on holiday. So we begin exercising, improve our eating and try sleeping better. Everywhere in the media, television, radio or magazines, there's advice on looking after ourselves and our bodies. Often, however, it tells us to stop things we enjoy: smoking, alcohol, foods too fatty, sweet or salty, too much television. In short, health requires sacrificing these little pleasures. Some ask, "What's the point of sacrificing all this? What will I have left?"

[00:04:32] I find this a very interesting question. Must we abandon all little pleasures to feel well? Isn't there a way to reconcile health and pleasure?

[00:04:50] I'll try answering today. For now, let go of your sweets, put out your cigarette, put down your wine and listen!

[00:05:13] France has many institutions helping citizens stay healthy. I don't mean doctors' surgeries or hospitals, but institutions researching what is healthy and what isn't. They frequently publish recommendations: no more than ten alcoholic drinks weekly, very difficult for French people, less sugar and charcuterie, meaning pork products like ham or dry sausage, and more vegetables.

[00:06:03] A proverb says, "Prevention is better than cure." In other words, do everything to stop illness occurring: that's prevention. To prevent diseases, we feel we must absolutely

follow every institutional instruction. Otherwise, we risk illness or cancer. Recommendations become synonymous with prohibitions and restrictions, things we mustn't do. "Not doing" is almost always negative.

[00:06:51] Hearing all these prohibitions, we might think the messages become counterproductive. "Counterproductive" means producing the opposite of the intended result. Why? Because people become fed up. They don't want to be told all day what they can't do. Like children: forbid something and they want it even more!

[00:07:34] Advertising campaigns informing us of dangers are also always shocking, like cigarette-pack images. I don't know whether it's the same where you live, but many European countries display shocking photographs of disease, tumours and people killed by tobacco on cigarette packets.

[00:08:05] Besides institutional campaigns, the media give endless advice. Health is very profitable for them because people are increasingly interested. They want to stay healthy as long as possible, a kind of eternal youth. Almost daily, there's new advice: avoid this or that food, stay away from radio-electrical waves, don't reuse plastic drinking bottles, and so on. The "experts" aren't always reliable or trustworthy. Celebrities also explain what they do to stay fit, and people follow their advice like a magic recipe.

[00:09:28] New technology now advises us too. Smartphones can count daily walking steps. Sometimes we hear ten thousand steps are necessary to be active enough. But recommendations vary between applications: eight thousand, twelve thousand, twenty thousand! Or twenty minutes walking daily, sometimes thirty! It's hard to make sense of it. We no longer know whom to believe.

[00:10:12] Other smartphone applications "scientifically" analyse eating and correct diets. We enter everything we eat, and they calculate whether certain foods are missing, whether we need more vitamins or protein, for example. It isn't only food. There are applications to improve sleep, meaning how we sleep, exercise and so on. Some companies are even developing medical-diagnosis applications: they ask about symptoms, then tell you your illness or problem.

[00:11:15] Again, recommendations can differ greatly according to the application. Be careful, because we don't always know who's behind it, which "experts" developed it.

[00:11:34] We can imagine that in a few years smartphones will monitor everything about our health and constantly advise us on staying fit.

[00:11:53] Yet hearing and reading all these restrictions and recommendations can ultimately feel oppressive. Everything we do is controlled. There's a model for good health everyone should follow. Otherwise, we're considered deviant individuals, people not respecting social rules. Almost as if living in a dictatorship: the dictatorship of well-being!

[00:12:31] This too can be counterproductive! In a dictatorship, we constantly think of forbidden things, often things we enjoy, like cake or alcohol. Ultimately, all these prohibitions create frustration. Stress and frustration are harmful, meaning bad for health. So this dictatorship of well-being achieves the opposite of its aims.

[00:13:14] Couldn’t we imagine another way of staying healthy, a more positive view? That’s what we’ll explore in the second part.

[00:13:42] We might imagine technological progress and all these applications letting everyone live to 120. Advancing science will lead us to adapt behaviour for better health. If rational, we won’t do unhealthy things. Choosing them anyway, such as smoking or drinking, would mean we aren’t psychologically strong enough or are victims of our environment, for example a family where everyone smokes.

[00:14:32] In reality, we aren’t rational beings, at least not entirely. We often do things knowing they’re bad for us. We may continue smoking despite knowing cancer risks, because it’s pleasurable. We may drink to enjoy time with friends, even knowing we’ll feel ill next day. Do you know the name of that state after a drinking party, when your head hurts and you have no energy? It’s “la gueule de bois”, a hangover. If partying with French-speaking friends and drinking too much, next day say, “J’ai la gueule de bois”, I have a hangover.

[00:15:35] Anyway, forgive the digression. I’m trying to show we want to believe humans are rational, but every day brings evidence otherwise.

[00:15:50] The problem with all this advice is its moralising vision. Experts tell us how to live based on study results, but also personal values. They decide what’s good or bad for the population and try to influence daily behaviour.

[00:16:21] Fortunately, other approaches to health education exist: approaches that aren’t moralising and respect individual freedom of choice.

[00:16:37] This approach aims to make people autonomous and responsible. Again, compare educating children. Constantly telling them what to do and avoid without explaining why prevents understanding. They can’t become adults either, because they don’t know how to make their own decisions. They only know how to obey, or not, rules adults set.

[00:17:21] You might reply health advice isn’t rules. Perhaps not yet, but gradually it becomes so. Take cigarettes. After the Second World War, cigarette consumption exploded in France. French people began smoking heavily, initially mainly men, then women too. From the seventies, the government adopted laws restricting advertising and banning smoking in places like hospitals. Later came transport bans, on trains and planes, and in 2008 public places such as cafés and restaurants, except designated smoking rooms. Meanwhile, cigarette taxes rose greatly to discourage smoking. The government is currently considering ten euros a packet, twice the price ten years ago.

[00:18:58] Personally, that doesn’t bother me at all. Statistically, smokers are likelier to develop cancer, so I find paying more normal, since they’ll use publicly funded hospitals. I don’t smoke either, so no cigarette smell around me is more pleasant.

[00:19:27] On the other hand, initial advice, “Don’t smoke because it’s unhealthy”, becomes effectively a rule, as smoking becomes harder. I recently read a study showing cigarette consumption is highly unequal: nowadays it’s mostly disadvantaged, poor people who smoke. Prevention therefore isn’t working in these environments, perhaps because people aren’t well informed.

[00:20:12] Smoking can even become shameful, like obesity. Previously, smoking was cool. Now some think smoking means lacking willpower, being weak. Cigarettes become a kind of social marker.

[00:20:36] We can question these policies' effectiveness. French cigarette sales fell 20% in ten years, so perhaps they work. But perhaps even better methods of fighting smoking exist.

[00:20:58] For example, last year France's Health Ministry launched quite an innovative campaign to persuade people to stop. Let's listen to an excerpt to hear its message.

[00:21:23] "I'm Stéphane. I've smoked for thirty years. November is Tobacco-Free Month, so I've decided to give it a try. If, like me, you're among France's eight million people wanting to stop, join Tobacco-Free Month. A month without smoking makes quitting five times more likely. Join the Tobacco-Free Month movement at tabacinfoservice.fr."

[00:21:42] What's interesting is the collective challenge. Rather than stopping alone, everyone stops together on 1 November. They can support and help each other. The campaign makes you feel less alone in your struggle, part of a team: something positive. It says managing one smoke-free month makes permanent quitting five times more likely. Motivating, isn't it?

[00:22:34] The campaign doesn't make smokers feel guilty. Instead, it encourages a collective commitment. I think that's wonderful! Other advertisements showed children encouraging parents to quit, supporting their struggle. Another positive, motivating message!

[00:23:05] To encourage good habits, I think we should favour pleasure over guilt. Too often, we feel health requires depriving ourselves of everything. "To deprive oneself" means abstaining, not doing something we want. For example, avoiding sweets despite wanting them very much!

[00:23:39] Seeing things as deprivation and prohibitions isn't very motivating. They can also become obsessions, thought about all day. We simply await the moment to do what we want so much.

[00:24:02] Instead, I think we should concentrate on positive aspects: set goals, measure progress, reward ourselves upon succeeding. Think of all the good the new habit will bring, not what we sacrifice.

[00:24:30] Health debate must also become public. Involve people so they participate, share knowledge and ask questions. Experts don't have a monopoly, especially since they've often been wrong before.

[00:24:56] Nor is there a magic recipe working for everyone. We're all different, living in different environments. Take these factors into account with a local approach. Some problems and diseases are more prevalent in one region than another, so recommendations can't be identical for everyone.

[00:25:35] Perhaps pleasure itself helps health. Many people lived very long despite unhealthy lifestyles. Perhaps you know the longest-lived person was a Frenchwoman, Jeanne

Calment. She died in 1997 aged 122. One hundred and twenty-two! Can you imagine? She smoked nearly all her life and ate lots of chocolate! Of course, I’m not saying smoking and chocolate make you live longer. On the contrary, numerous studies show smoking increases cancer risk. I simply want to underline we still don’t know everything about the human body.

[00:26:39] So remain open-minded and work together to live healthier and longer.

[00:26:53] We’re reaching the end. Thank you for listening all the way through. Seeing more and more listeners, people learning French, makes me very happy, and I’m very pleased if the podcast helps. To help me, leave a comment on iTunes or your podcast application. That will make me happier still!

[00:27:26] Next week is episode twenty, and I’ve prepared a little surprise. Be there! See you soon!